Challenge Stigma | Find Peace

FrontlineFolks | Guide #16

Chronic Pain and Tension: When Your Body Never Stands Down

A Field Guide for Frontline Folks and Their Families

Pain and stress amplify each other until you break the loop.

By Michael Jenkins, MS, MSW, LCSW
Never Forgotten Services, PLLC

Disclaimer

This guide is for general education only.

It is not:

- Therapy
- Medical care
- A crisis service
- Individualized advice

Reading this guide does not create a therapist–client relationship with the author or with Never Forgotten Services, PLLC.

If you are in crisis or thinking about harming yourself or someone else, call 988 in the United States, go to your nearest emergency room, or contact your local emergency services.

If you want mental health treatment, please contact a licensed provider in your state or call the number on the back of your insurance card.

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1. What Is Happening in Your System

Chronic pain in frontline work isn't just old injuries—it's a nervous system that never fully downshifts. When your body stays in high-alert mode, muscles stay contracted, inflammation stays elevated, and pain signals get amplified. What started as tension becomes chronic: jaw clenching, neck and shoulder pain, low back strain, headaches. Your body is holding the stress you can't process, and pain becomes the constant background noise of your life.

Common pain patterns in frontline folks

- Jaw clenching and TMJ pain (especially during sleep or stress).
- Chronic neck and shoulder tension ('carrying the weight').
- Low back pain from long shifts in static postures or gear weight.
- Tension headaches from sustained muscle contraction.
- Old injuries that won't heal or keep flaring.
- Guarded posture and reduced mobility (body protecting itself).

> **Pain-stress loop:**
> Stress increases muscle tension and inflammation. Pain increases stress and catastrophizing. The loop tightens until something breaks.

2. Why It Gets Worse Under Frontline Load

Frontline work loads your body with physical and psychological stress. Long shifts in static postures (sitting, standing, wearing gear), suppressed emotional activation (can't release stress in real-time), and inadequate recovery between shifts mean your muscles never fully relax. Add old injuries, poor sleep, and chronic inflammation, and you get a body stuck in defensive tension. Pain signals get amplified by a sensitized nervous system—what used to be a 3/10 now feels like a 7/10.

Typical amplifiers

- Static postures during long shifts: Sitting in vehicles, standing on scene, wearing heavy gear.
- Suppressed stress: Can't discharge activation in real-time, so body holds it.
- Old injuries never fully rehabbed: Compensatory patterns create new pain.
- Poor sleep: Pain lowers sleep quality, sleep debt amplifies pain.
- Chronic inflammation from stress and poor recovery.

> *Why this works: reducing total load and improving predictability lowers baseline arousal and restores decision quality.*

3. What To Do This Week

You can't eliminate pain overnight, but you can break the pain-stress loop. Movement, heat, breathing, and micro-recovery windows reduce tension and restore some mobility.

1. Add 3 micro-mobility breaks per shift: 90 seconds of movement (neck rolls, shoulder shrugs, spinal twists, hip openers). Breaks the static posture loop.
2. Use heat or ice after work: 10 minutes on problem areas. Heat relaxes muscles, ice reduces inflammation.
3. Pair breathing with stretching: Slow exhale while stretching reduces guarding and deepens release.
4. Track pain before and after movement: Prove to your brain that movement helps. Data overrides fear-avoidance.
5. Massage or self-myofascial release: Foam roller, lacrosse ball, or hands-on work 2-3x per week.
6. Physical therapy for persistent pain: PT teaches you how to move without compensation patterns.

> Field rule: make the action small enough that you can still do it on a bad day.

4. For Partners and Family

Household stability improves when everyone knows the plan before stress spikes.

- Name pain level early: 'I'm at a 6 today, feeling tight and short-fused.' Prevents misreading pain as hostility.
- Support movement: Encourage breaks, walks, stretching—not 'toughing it out.'
- Don't take guarded posture personally: Pain makes people withdraw and protect.
- Offer practical help: Heat packs, massage, covering tasks that aggravate pain.

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5. When To Escalate Care

Self-management is a starting point, not a lifetime sentence. Escalate when function, safety, or relationships keep declining.

- Pain persists despite self-care and movement.
- Pain is limiting work capacity, sleep, or daily function.
- You're relying on pain meds or alcohol to manage pain daily.
- Old injuries keep flaring with no clear recovery pattern.
- Pain is spreading or changing (new areas, different quality).

6. 7-Day Field Drill

Use the worksheet daily for one week. Measure trigger intensity, response size, and recovery time.

> **Daily drill:**
> Name one trigger, one body signal, and one reset action.
> At end of week, keep what worked and remove what did not.

Worksheet 1: Worksheet: Chronic Pain and Tension: When Your Body Never Stands Down

Use this to track chronic pain and full-body tension in real time and build a repeatable response plan.

Where did this pattern show up this week?

List specific moments at work, at home, or during transition.

What did it cost you?

Include effect on body, mood, decisions, and relationships.

What two actions will you run for the next 7 days?

Choose small, realistic actions you can perform under stress.

1. Trigger:

What event, cue, or context activated this pattern?

2. Early body signal:

What did your body do first?

3. Reset action used:

What 30-90 second action lowered intensity?

4. Better next response:

Write the exact behavior you will use next time.

> Track this daily for one week, then adjust based on what actually worked.

Worksheet 2: Worksheet: Chronic Pain and Tension: When Your Body Never Stands Down - Partner/Team Check-In

Use this page for one short, practical check-in each week.

What do others notice first when this pattern is active?

Ask for concrete observations, not labels.

What support helps most?

List what helps and what makes it worse.

What agreement will we practice this week?

One clear behavior from each side.

1. Signal phrase:

What phrase means pause and reset?

2. Time-to-return:

How long until re-engagement after a pause?

3. Repair step:

What specific repair happens if things go sideways?

> Keep check-ins short, specific, and repeatable.

Closing

You've seen and carried more than most people will ever know.

Blow ups and shutdowns are not proof that you're broken or that your relationship is doomed.

They are signs that your nervous system has been running in survival mode for a long time.

The fact that you picked up this guide and read it matters.

You are choosing to be intentional about how you show up for the people who matter to you.

That choice is a lot more powerful than having flawless days.

About the Author

Michael Jenkins, MS, MSW, LCSW

Founder, Never Forgotten Services, PLLC

Michael is a U.S. Army combat veteran and licensed clinical social worker who specializes in working with military, veterans, and first responders—our frontline folks. After leaving the military, he spent years fighting his own demons and trying to figure out why he could hold it together on the job but feel completely wrecked at home. The turning point was realizing he wasn't the only one living that split life—and that nobody should have to feel that alone, confused, or broken by what the job asks of them.

Since then, his work has focused on trauma, the impact of high-stress jobs on home life, and helping families make sense of what the job brings home. He uses plain language, zero shame, and a "you're not crazy, this actually makes sense" approach to help frontline folks and their families understand what's happening in their nervous systems and learn how to move through the chaos together.